My first meeting with Albie occurred when I was a 15-year-old schoolboy and he was playing for the South African Under-19 team; he was a dominant all-rounder who could bowl fast and hit the ball further than anyone else.

As the years passed, the three of us began playing in the same matches and tournaments, generally as teammates, sometimes as opponents, and we got along well. Soon after we started playing for the Titans, we decided to rent a place in Equestria, a suburb east of Pretoria, and to stay together.

Those were great days, and we enjoyed many afternoons and evenings, and late nights and early mornings, when we would braai and have a few beers, and chat. We were almost inseparable, driving together to practices and matches, and to the airport to catch flights ... and so our cricketing and social lives continued until one day Albie announced that he and his long-time girlfriend, Marthmari, were getting married.

'That's not a problem,' Morné and I chorused. 'We don't have an issue if she moves in with us.'

I'm not exactly sure what we were thinking, other than that we didn't want our living arrangements to change, and the four of us did live together for a while until Albie put his foot down and said we should move out of the flat and give him and his new wife some space. Somewhat reluctantly, Morné and I found a place to rent 600 metres down the road but, as the weeks passed, even living this distance from our former flatmate proved intolerable. Within six months, we moved again and rented the apartment next door to Albie and Marthmari.

Albie produced many fantastic performances for South Africa, with both bat and ball, playing in 108 limited-overs internationals between 2004 and 2015, but the position of all-rounder is notoriously difficult to retain in any international ODI or T20 team simply because the expectations are so unrealistic. People reckon you should win the match almost every time you bat and almost every time you bowl.

You typically bat at No. 7, arriving at the crease when there are runs